scheme blossomed, the kiosk began selling Scotch whisky, Strasbourg goose-liver pate, French champagne, Swiss chocolate, clothing, toys, jewellery, cosmetics – and almost anything else hard currency could buy. East Germans could only press their noses against the window and curse their Ostmark, which was hard-earned and yet worth little. Over time, more kiosks were set up at border crossing points, hotels, rest areas on the transit routes between the Federal Republic of Germany and West Berlin and at train stations, airports and ferry ports.

The SED Sixth Congress, from 15–21 January, launched the start of a momentous year in GDR politics. The carefully choreographed event saw delegates from more than thirty countries, including China, arrive in East Berlin. Yet even before unpacking, Khrushchev stole the headlines after lumbering off a train at Berlin's Ostbahnhof and bellowing at a group of Western journalists: 'you people in the West … we are just waiting for you to disappear from the face of the earth. The future belongs to us. Your times are over. I shall shout a loud 'Hurrah' when capitalism is buried.' Speaking in front of a red curtain bearing the party's insignia, and flanked by SED grandees, including Honecker, his tirade continued:

We will not have a war to bring the socialist system of society to another country because we think that is an internal matter for each country. A lot of nonsense is talked about our personal relations with Herr Ulbricht. Let me tell you that this is just so much speculation. Herr Ulbricht is the model carpenter, and I am the locksmith.

8

Looking back on that day, Honecker recounted how, strangely enough, Khrushchev was more popular in the GDR than with his fellow countrymen. 'He had a very graphic turn of phrase and was very clever.' He remembered: